

Regime Change and Credibility: Implications of Democratic Backsliding on Deterrence

“As democracy is perfected, the office of president represents, more and more closely, the inner soul of the people. On some great and glorious day the plain folks of the land will reach their heart's desire at last and the White House will be adorned by a downright moron.” -- H. L. Mencken, 1920

A. Introduction

The 2024 election offered American voters two distinct visions of domestic and national security. Kamala Harris' campaign touted American security would come from deepening investments in global institutions and alliances (Spetalnick & Lewis 2024), while also framing the election as “a choice between freedom and chaos” (Thompson 2024). She promoted voter protections, such as the John Lewis Voting Rights Advancement Act and the Freedom to Vote Act, and painted Trump as dangerous to democracy against his claims to jail political opponents (Farrow et al 2024; Berman 2024). Oppositely, Donald Trump promised “America First” -- an isolationist approach that criticized NATO leaders (Barrow 2025). At the same time, Trump contested the 2020 election and promised to pardon those who attacked the capitol on January 6 (Esomonu 2025). In the face of two ongoing, active wars that involve nuclear-armed states, 2024 offered a moment to contrast the competing ideologies: does strength, particularly the ability to deter aggression, come from the liberal notion of building up democratic practices or from a realist notion of military self-investment?

This question is particularly pertinent in shifting geopolitics, when the United States' place in global leadership is increasingly questioned. In the unipolar moment, the American role in the world order was linked to theories about democratization creating peace. Democratic peace theory (DPT) posits that two democracies are less likely to go to war than two non-democracies or than a democracy and another regime type (Russett 1994). This has been significant for international relations theory, as DPT “comes as close as anything we have to an empirical law in international relations.” (Levy 1988)¹ Building from DPT, Fearon (1995) famously hypothesized that, beyond peace, democracies had an advantage in threat-making because they faced higher audience costs. Yet some political scientists of the Cold War considered non-democracies to make more credible nuclear threats because they had fewer constraints on decision-making (Hymans 2011). The United States attempts to balance providing its allies with nuclear assurances with ensuring its nuclear threats are credible to protect itself, trying to figure out when being a democracy is good for its nuclear policy (Saunders 2019). As the United States loses its global hegemony, the door is opened for questions on how to maintain national security.

¹ However, DPT has long been criticized in methodology, theory, and consistency (for example: Rathbun, Parker, & Pomeroy 2024).

At the same time, the domestic political environment has witnessed a trend of democratic backsliding for the past decade (Mechova et al 2017). Democracy is understood to be a political system where most adult residents are legally entitled to vote, a high proportion of these adults do vote, and the election is free, contested and fair (Dahl 2005). Democratic backsliding is the period when an established democratic state regresses on its commitment to public control. It can be observed through election manipulation and executive overreach, which, while imperfect criteria, offer a way to monitor institutional moves away from democratic principles. Notably, the United States has indicated democratic decline since 2010, from acts that limit voter registration to expansions of executive powers (Williamson 2023).

To put the two observable phenomena in conversation with each other, this article looks at how and why credibility is affected by democratic backsliding as a way of understanding how democratic performances bolster deterrence. This article interrogates the role of democratic backsliding in the credibility of nuclear weapons threats and assurances. Specifically, I hypothesize that moments of democratic decline affect nuclear credibility by creating the conditions to undermine deterrence, ultimately allowing for deterrence failures.

To understand the strategic effects of democratic recoil, I first present a literature review of how international security commitments, particularly nuclear commitments, require credibility that is based in legitimacy and how perception is a central part of that credibility. I also review perceptions of democratic and non-democratic practices. From there, I present a theory that elite and public disempowerment, which result from democratic recoil, facilitates deterrence failures, either escalation or adversarial moves, through groupthink, indecision, disconnection, or apathy. I probe the plausibility of this theory with two cases, India under Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Israel under Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. I conclude with the implications of my theory on contemporary American nuclear credibility following the re-election of Trump.

B. Literature Review

In this article, I frame democratic practices and international security commitments as relational, in that actions are taken by state leaders but the legitimacy of these actions can only be given by their audience. In both cases, information cannot be credibly communicated.

As the adage goes, once power is given, it cannot be easily taken away. Any election risks a consolidation of power in the executive, who may be unwilling to relinquish control of the state. Democracies require leaders to use certain language and routines as a show accountability to voters (Roe-Crines 2025). In democracies, citizens are inherently unequal in their access to resources that can alter policy (Dahl 2005). Class, access, and wealth determine ability to engage politically, with elites given a structural advantage in political agency. Yet leaders adhere to rhetorical conventions for general audiences to signal they are upholding certain principles for mass support from their policies (Crines & Heppell 2017). Electoral systems that provide voting rights for the majority of a population give the audience power over officials, creating a need for

leadership behavior to conform to expectations. The actual effects of this behavior may be minimal, in that the public may have limited control over policy outcomes, but the representation matters for buy-in from their audience and perceived external constraint on decision-making.

Leaders make commitments to both the public and elite audiences as a way of getting (re)elected. These commitments can conflict, and this conflict can be observed through public performances (Dahl 2005). It is observed by multiple audiences concurrently, which makes public actions subject to constraint. Democratic leaders are observable to the domestic public, both elected and bureaucratic domestic elites, and international actors, both allies and adversaries (Tully 2012). Leaders want to avoid other powerful actors with different objectives, “elites,” from undermining their agency or public support. Therefore, they try to bargain with elites to avoid them cuing the public (Saunders 2024) or they avoid performing in a way that falls outside of acceptable behavior. Beyond that, leaders have internalized a sense that other actors can punish them for using violence or reneging their commitments (De Mesquita & Lalman 2008; Kertzer & Brutger 2016). Democratic recoil can then be understood as periods when leaders are no longer bound by the will of the public or elected elites; commitments to private actors are what they publicly act on.

For international security commitments, leaders have incentives to cheat due to the anarchic nature of the system (Waltz 1979; Fearon 1995; Mearsheimer 2011). To assure commitments, both in responding to adversaries and in aiding allies, states build reputations over long time horizons, formalized in institutions, and frame their actions in a way that incurs legitimacy to prevent immediate adversarial responses (Ikenberry 2000; Hurd 1999; Goddard 2009). Legitimacy requires wide support and public buy-in; in the international system, legitimacy is conferred by other states not dictated by hegemons (Finnemore 2009). The security of a state requires specific rhetorical and behavioral moves as a way to make threats and assurances believable to other states.

Commitments around nuclear weapons require even more specific rhetoric due to their high-cost and rare-use nature. While nuclear weapons are physical objects, doctrine around nuclear weapons comes from their social context and thus those that manage nuclear arsenals are socialized to particular routines that they believe will make nuclear weapons most useful. Nuclear weapons have been, theoretically and practically, held distinct from other weapons for a range of reasons – the amount of immediate and indiscriminate damage they can cause, the lasting radioactivity they leave, and the corresponding ethical weight of such factors. Whether it be for normative or tactical reasons, nuclear weapons are situated outside of conventional war plans (Jervis 1986). Their limited use as a wartime weapon further perpetuates the idea of a normative commitment to nonuse (Tannenwald 2007). Planning around nuclear weapons use has since become a largely theoretical task: because they are infrequently used and the impact of their use is so large, nuclear strategy uses models laden with assumptions about how to make threats credible without making actual nuclear use likely.

Nuclear strategy in the United States has largely been based on deterrence, the theory that the promise of an unacceptable level of damage will change the cost analysis of other actors and make them less likely to take certain actions. Nuclear deterrence relies on the belief a leader *can* and *will* use their nuclear arsenal; the leader must convince others that they have both the intention and capability to use nuclear weapons. Beyond that, it relies on others understanding correctly the actions that would lead to escalation (Schelling 1996). Their value then comes not from their actual use but their threat and its related social connotation (Biswas 2014). Nuclear weapons are thus seen as a tool to influence adversary action by simply their presence. The questions of if deterrence works, how it works, and whether or not it makes the world less prone to great power conflict are perennial to the field (Zagare & Kilgour 2000). Importantly, deterrence remains the basis for American nuclear policy and for deterrence to work threats must be considered credible (Mazarr 2018).

Perception is integral to deterrence theory because deterrence relies on an adversary deciding that a state is willing to punish them no matter the cost to itself. The perceived willingness for self-destruction, called the rationality of irrationality, makes the threat of nuclear weapons credible because it makes nuclear weapons usable, even though it is understood that any nuclear use against a nuclear-armed adversary would result in catastrophic damage for all parties. States perform this willingness in different dances known as brinkmanship – escalatory pathways, automation of procedures, hair-trigger systems (Schelling 1966). Using escalatory language, even if not entirely credible, creates the possibility of escalation. The practice of performing this willingness for others also creates routines and incentives within the state for viability of nuclear escalation (Ellsberg 2017). Deterrence fails at “the absence of a clear commitment or sufficient credibility or capability” (Orme 198, 96). In other words, if an adversary cannot understand a state’s commitment or no longer perceives a state as willing or able to use their nuclear arsenal, that state can no longer successfully deter their adversary. In cases of democratic recoil, capability stays the same, but mechanisms for maintaining commitments and credibility may change.

Putting democratic behavior and international security commitments in conversation with each other, perception about adherence to democratic norms and practice has been theorized as an important factor in creating credibility. There is an expectation that a leader’s democratic identity makes them less willing to go to war (Debs & Goemans 2010) because democracy requires certain habits of its leaders, and these habits allow others to have expectations of the leaders’ behaviors (Hopf 2010). Particularly, international relations scholars since the end of World War II have discussed the “democratic advantage” -- democracies are more likely to win the wars they fight because they select conflicts they can win and fight more effectively once in those wars (Reiter & Stam 2002, 11). Additionally, Fearon (1994) argued that democracies have higher audience costs so they make more credible threats. The argument, that democratic processes create more transparency in motives and incentive to adhere to the public will, implies “democracies should be able to signal their intentions to other states more credibly and clearly

than authoritarian states can, perhaps ameliorating the security dilemma between democratic states.” (Fearon 1994, 577) Democratic commitments are harder to break because there’s a higher cost of backing down, meaning threats to go to war are more credible because a leader faces loss of domestic support. This theory has been nuanced – all leaders face audience costs and different audiences have leverages over the leader (Weeks 2008). It is reasonable to assume that if these practices change, other actors alter their expectations of leader behavior.

A change in democracy, or democratic backsliding, therefore matters for international security. Elite and public disempowerment are both requisite for democratic backsliding to occur, otherwise democracy is simply adapting to another form. If elites lose power but there are still mechanisms of public accountability, the leader is still subject to constraints of the public will or what they imagine the public will to be – which creates a populist democracy. If there are no mechanisms of public accountability, but there are still mechanisms for elites to hold the leader accountable, then elite democracy occurs. Democratic recoil can be observed through executive overreach and election interference (Williamson 2018). Election manipulation implies loss of public control over choosing the leader. It also means the leader has less incentive to follow the will of the public; there is no reason to adhere to public commitments because the public has fewer low-cost opportunities to remove leaders from power. Executive overreach means the leader has more autonomy from other branches of government (Hyde & Saunders 2020). Elite audiences have less leverage over leaders because of executive overreach. This is particularly important because elites cue the public on political nuclear debates (Gibbons & Petrovics 2024; Herzog et al 2022). Democratic recoil shows less domestic audience, both public and elite, constraint on leaders.

The practice of both the performance of credible commitment to using nuclear weapons and the performance of executive constraint by the public and elected elites creates internalized notions of the type of actor a leader is. Self-perception has implications for decision-makers, because it guides perceived incentive structures (Pomeroy 2025; Jervis 2017). The literature has not yet considered the effect of democratic recoil on perceived commitment to nuclear weapons use. In other words, what credibility is lost when the performance of democracy drops?

C. Mechanisms of Strategic Effects: Groupthink, Indecision, Entrenchment, and Disconnection

How leaders perceive costs shapes their decision-making analysis. Democratic backsliding is a way that perceived costs change, in that a new audience incurs costs to the leaders. Instead of the public or elected elites, leaders may now only be constrained by mass mobilization or certain elites. I theorize that this change can affect deterrence because it changes the credibility of leader commitments. Credibility is perceived political commitment backed with technical capacity (Glaser 1992). This article looks at nuclear-armed democracies that have undergone democratic backsliding.

Some may argue that democratic changes are epiphenomenal to perceptions about deterrent credibility. In other words, factors like technology, leader personality, or geopolitical tensions are primary in shaping if an adversary will be deterred from certain actions. Yet heads of states continually seek to legitimize their arsenal through democracy and attempt to be seen as a “responsible nuclear power” (Ritchie 2013; Sasikumar 2007). This notion of “responsibility” allows states to show that they are in control of their nuclear arsenals and should be trusted with global leadership (Taylor & Hendry 2008). Countries use democratic fora and language for nuclear credibility, so this article takes an initial step into interrogating the relationship between the two.

Others argue that nuclear weapons programs are inherently undemocratic and therefore should already be excluded from considerations of regime-type. Nuclear weapons programs de-democratize a democratic state through secrecy from the public, leading to an inherent lack of accountability, and concentration of executive power, through implementing a rigid hierarchy in nuclear command and control (Fraise 2025; van Buuren 2025). This could imply that democratic performances are irrelevant because nuclear decisions are already undemocratic. However, that nuclear politics affect democracy doesn’t mean the inverse isn’t true. There is an explicit relationship between domestic institutions and nuclear politics (Saunders 2019). Thus, we should assume nuclear decisions and democratic behavior are linked and therefore can affect each other.

Deterrence failure can be observed through escalation, as continual attempts to assert high costs implies that threats on their own are not believed, or adversarial attacks, as it shows that adversaries no longer perceive the leader as committed to responding. Deterrence fails typically in moments of political instability (di Lonardo & Tyson 2022). If the democratic advantage implies high resolve, democratic recoil manifests deterrence failures precisely because high costs are no longer credible.

Democratic recoil can open the door to situations where there are fewer accountability mechanisms, particularly in moments of crisis, creating room for deterrence to fail. Elite disempowerment, where political rivals or bureaucrats lose moderating power over executive decisions, can lead to a leader not having advisors who oppose them (Jost 2024), allowing for **groupthink**, or no longer having requirements to bargain with opposing domestic elites, (Saunders 2024), allowing for **indecision**. Public disempowerment, where election manipulation means the leader no longer faces pressure from all constituents, can **entrench** leaders in their actions, removing the belligerent cost to leader action (Kertzer & Brutger 2016) and instead making them perceive a higher audience for peace if they rose to power on a nationalist agenda, or **disconnect** them from their domestic audiences, eroding Fearon’s “democratic advantage” in threat-making because leaders no longer face being voted out as a punishment for not living up to public commitments. These mechanisms can be visualized in Figure 1.

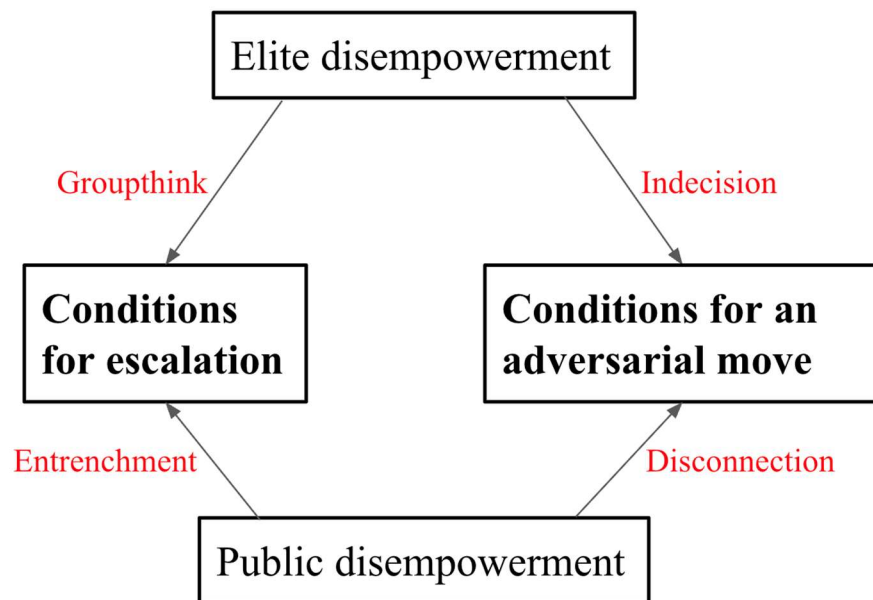


Figure 1: Effects of democratic recoil that can lead to deterrence failures through the mechanisms of groupthink, indecision, entrenchment, and disconnection.

A loss of elite control can lead to escalation or adversarial moves via groupthink or indecision, respectively. Elite disempowerment can constrict the diversity within institutions, incentives for a wide range of responses, and horizontal information flows. Members of a collectivity subconsciously and consciously constrain their critical thinking to adhere to the status quo, a phenomenon known as **groupthink** (Janis 2008). The absence of bargaining among elites makes certain options much more likely to be chosen than others. This makes the positive-feedback loops of escalation pathways, which are already present in nuclear strategy (Ellsberg 2017), more likely. Instead of dissent, actions are intensified which effectively induces ratcheting of escalation. So long as a leader has military favorability, escalation does not have to be controlled.

Elite disempowerment can also lead to **indecision**. The process of domestic bargaining institutes more buy-in by all actors (Mearsheimer & Rosato 2023). When leaders no longer must justify their decisions, red lines are less readable because there lacks an explicit consensus. Leaders may lose a mechanism for open deliberation allowing for reactionary moves or actions beyond a state's capacity. In response, other states may find their threats less credible because the thresholds for response are less believable or understandable (Schelling 1966).

When there is a loss of public accountability, leaders that rose to power through populism can become beholden to the ideas that they attribute to their success. Through **entrenchment**, leaders become inflexible in their responses, which allows for escalation, because they perceive a higher

cost to the status quo than escalation. As leaders have less public accountability, they perceive less of a cost from their domestic base, meaning there's less of a cost to belligerence (Kertzer & Brutger 2016).

Democratic leaders are punished for unnecessary or unexpected threats of violence by the public, so regression of democratic practices changes that constraint on leaders. **Disconnection** voids the belligerence cost, allowing leaders to escalate their threats. Leadership is perceived as more cost acceptant because the public will not or cannot hold them responsible. As states lose the "democratic advantage" that comes from audience costs, they must use other mechanisms to add credibility to their threats. This includes having to use violence and not simply the threat of violence as a commitment.

D. Methodology & Cases: Building Pathways

At its core, this article seeks to build a new theory on the relationship between democratic recoil and nuclear credibility. To test the plausibility of my theory, I use case studies to show my proposed relate to decreasing credibility, leaving room for future work to more quantitatively analyze the validity of this claim. Comparative case studies are optimal because they can identify relevant variables and middle-range generalizations that can be further analyzed (Achen and Snidal 1989, 146). This article falls within that realm because it creates precise scoping conditions, proposes mechanisms without logical fallacies, and uses empirical import as a test of those propositions (Gomm et al 2000, 124-125). The field should use the initial conjectures from this paper as a basis for deeper analysis.

The two cases of democratic backsliding affecting nuclear credibility are India, from 2014 to 2024, and Israel, from 2014 to 2024. India and Israel were seen as triumphs of democratization – a fragile flourishing in regions that were nondemocratic. Yet, in the mid-2010s, both Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu capitalized on existing ethnoreligious tension within the state, which had created an inherently unstable status quo maintained by repressing minorities, to develop anti-democratic norms and processes (Harel-Shalev 2010). Modi, embracing *Hindutva*, and Netanyahu, emphasizing Israeli Jewishness, promoted a new national vision through disproportionate welfare advantages to their base that created a dependent relationship with their electorate, religious appeals for ethnic divisions, and media attacks on critics (Rogenhofer & Panievsky 2020). Once elected, Modi and Netanyahu systematically undermined elite and public constraints on their power, observable through executive overreach and election manipulation, ultimately creating the conditions for democratic backsliding.

In the India case, the mechanisms of groupthink and entrenchment can be observed, leading to escalation in Operation Sindoor of May 2025. In the Israel case, the mechanisms of indecision and disconnection can be observed, leading to adversarial move of Hamas in October 2023. My theory does not qualify that only two mechanisms must be present.

India, 2014-2025

India as a Democracy

Indian democracy has long been scrutinized – can a hugely populated, multiethnic state share power peacefully and continually reinforce democratic institutions? Contested elections, a critical and present media, and peaceful power transfers marked the unexpected success of democracy in India. The puzzle of Indian democracy seemed to be solved by the perfect storms of conditions – historical, economic, ethnic, and political (Varshney 1998a). The legacy of British colonialism set the stage for the democratic institutions, observable by political leaders in India; partial self-rule allowed for indigenous politicians in certain territories (e.g., princely states like Kashmir and Hyderabad) while the independence movement allowed for national leaders to emerge with experience (Weiner 1989). The Indian National Congress was conditioned to rule as a competitive political party and was successful, contrasted to other decolonized states. Economically, Indian democracy was not predestined – the existence of a large class of agricultural workers meant that commercialization could have easily led to dictatorship, as wealth is theorized to be a requisite of sustained democracy (Lipset 1959). Yet the Green Revolution prevented food shortages and Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru’s state-led industrialization program preserved “democracy over development” (Varshney 1998b). The dispersed nature of ethnic divisions in India meant that there was little direct confrontation between ethnic groups and, when direct confrontation did occur, it remained isolated. Finally, the early political leadership of India, such as Nehru, accepted institutional constraints and participated in democratic norms (Varshney 1998a). Indian democracy existed and persisted, but only conditionally.

In 2014, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) won a parliamentary majority for the first time, changing the constraints on India’s public and elite accountability mechanisms. Reported scores for “level of democracy” in India have gone down since 2014 (Coppedge et al 2024). In practice, the power of the executive has grown alongside crackdowns on dissent and a rise in Hindu nationalism (Vaishnav 2024). The historic power transition to the BJP is not why analysts, both in and out of the country, claim Indian democracy is failing. Using the two indicators, executive overreach and election interference, we can see changes into how democracy has changed under Modi’s rule – election interference, promotion of illiberalism, and increasing political deference of once-neutral election watchdogs (Vaishnav 2024, 63-64).

Executive overreach is observable via the reversal of Article 370, the partisan creation of an electoral funding vehicle, and the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) bureaucratic appointments. Article 370 of the Constitution of India gave “a semblance of constitutional autonomy” to Jammu and Kashmir. Its abrogation, a parliamentary action without state legislative approval, aggravated tension and is regarded as a reignition of tension with Pakistan (Alam et al 2020). When implementing the change, the central government cut all communication links in the state and placed virtually every opposition leader under house arrest (Vaishnav 2024, 65). In addition,

the BJP passed a series of campaign finance acts, culminating in the 2018 Finance Act, that allowed for electoral bonds. Electoral bonds are the only way for a party to get foreign funding and any organization receiving foreign funding can be investigated by federal law enforcement. Under the 2018 Finance Law, donors became anonymous and the Rajya Sabha, the upper house of Parliament, could no longer veto these bonds. The executive branch could follow campaign finance trails, but civil society and the public were excluded from this knowledge (Vaishnav 2024, 66). This, unsurprisingly, created partiality in campaign issuance, as “the BJP garnered 97.7% of funds that were legitimized by surreptitious changes to campaign finance laws!” (Khaitan 2020, 61) At the same time, the Modi government evaded accountability by incrementally fusing the party and the state under a veneer of nationalism. The PMO rerouted bureaucratic appointments to promote party loyalty and override safeguards meant to preserve the interests of state governments (Vaishnav 2024, 67).

Election manipulation has been both indirect, by manipulating citizenship pathways and repressing critical media, and direct, as institutions that monitor parties and elections have less control and opposition leaders being placed under investigation. Indirectly, the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) allowed for selective voter registration, primarily used to disallow Muslim migrants from this citizenship pathway. In addition, the crackdown on free speech and civil liberties limited citizens’ ability to critically observe and commentate on elections. Although defamation and sedition laws have always allowed the ruling party to control narratives, the BJP “has deployed these tools more intensively, and with greater clarity of purpose, than did its predecessors” (Vaishnav 2024, 65). This included banning anonymous reporting on government activities (PRS Legislative Research 2021) and censoring speech, such as a BBC documentary on Modi’s role in the Gujarat riots (Ellis-Petersen 2023).

In a more formal way, India has undone the sanctity of her elections since 2014 through politicization of election accountability measures and harassment of opposition members. Like most democratic states, India assures elections are free and fair through “fourth branches” -- federal institutions that act as a watchdog for election interference. The Election Commission of India (ECI) serves this role. Since the 1990s, the ECI has used its agency at the state and national level on incumbents and challengers to limit electoral malpractice (Kapur et al 2018). But the ECI has, since 2020, become suspected of executive deference and defy operational accountability (Kumar 2022; Bhat 2021). In addition to the ECI, India has other referee institutions, like the Supreme Court, the Lokpal, and the Central Information Commission, to make all parties adhere to the same rules (Kapur & Mehta 2007). Over the past decade, they have experienced meddling, been ignored, or ceded power to avoid confrontation with the popular Modi government (Vaishnav 2025). Alongside these changes, the BJP is “selectively investigate, prosecute, or harass prominent opposition members” (Vaishnav 2024, 69) -- there have been a 400% increase in investigations since 2014 and 95% of these investigations are to the opposition party (Tiwary 2022). Most recently, Congress party leader Rahul Gandhi was detained after

alleging voter manipulation – a blatantly political move after Gandhi the ECI released digital voter records (Farooquee 2025).

India is a backsliding democracy where elites are losing power or afraid to challenge because of the populist momentum of the Modi government. At the same time, the public cannot freely criticize the government and there are questions about the robustness of coming elections.

India, under Groupthink and Entrenchment

Contemporary India suffers from groupthink, where its political leaders adhere to the status quo, undermining deterrence because threats are continuously escalated, and entrenchment, where Modi's reputation was staked on establishing hard lines so he faced "peace costs" more than those of belligerence. These mechanisms created the conditions for an escalation; India could not convince Pakistani groups of the high costs of action, which increased the violence of Indian commitments to be taken seriously thus making possible Operation Sindoor.

India successfully tested its first nuclear device in 1974 and currently stands as one of the nine nuclear-armed countries in the world with approximately 180 nuclear weapons (Perkovich 1999; Kristensen et al 2025). Security concerns over China and Pakistan are conventionally seen as the primary driver of India's desire for nuclear weapons – a way to avoid coercion from either state (Thayer 1995). Though this was how the United States interpreted Indian logic, domestic politics, specifically the "ambition to be regarded as a major power in a world where the recognized great powers rely on nuclear weapons for security and prestige" (Perkovich 1999, 6) seems to be the source of India's nuclear ambitions. India, as a leader of the Non-Aligned Movement, actively advocated against nuclear weapons and held a moral antagonism towards nuclear weapons (Abraham 2008). Yet it later chose to repudiate the "nuclear apartheid" by developing its own arsenal. While security conditions matter, India's nuclear program was largely developed to assert India's status as an important yet responsible state. To that end, India adheres to a No First Use (NFU) and "credible minimum deterrence" (CMD) strategy – a pledge not to use nuclear weapons first and maintain the fewest nuclear weapons necessary to deter its adversaries. Additionally, India upholds the Non-Nuclear Aggression Agreement with Pakistan, a bilateral decision to prohibit attacks on nuclear installations and facilities (Akhtar & Neog 2024).

Since the 1947 partitioning of the British colony into India and Pakistan, their relationship has been dominated by tension with four escalations to war (Hussain 2019). The violence between the states has been attributed to myriad sources – including geography, religion, regional politics, and economics (Ijaz 2017). These explanations offer reasons why the states are perpetually mistrustful of each other, from nearness allowing tensions to become active conflict more often (Mohan 2016) to cultural differences creating social friction between Hindus and Muslims (Sandhu 2016). There is a vast literature on India-Pakistan relations that this article will not attempt to cover. Importantly, the relationship has rapidly deteriorated under Modi's leadership;

an increase in Indian provocations, both territorial and rhetorical, has pushed aside any thoughts of peace (Ijaz 2017). This has actualized into eruptions of violence between the two states – in 2019, Pakistani terrorist suicide-bombed Indian police in Kashmir, which led to India taking away Kashmiri autonomy. In 2025, Pakistani militant group The Resistance Front (TRF) killed 26 people in Pahalgam, which led to India canceling water management treaty and de facto peace agreement, the Indus Waters Treaty. It is important to note that Pakistan has not claimed either of these attacks. This then led to Pakistan suspending the Simla Agreement and escalated into cross-border exchange, Operation Sindoor (Sutherland 2025). Operation Sindoor, "the most significant between the two nuclear-armed adversaries in several decades" (Clary 2025), witnessed the first use of Indian cruise missiles against Pakistan and 40 to 100 Pakistani people dead (Inter-Services Public Relations of Pakistan 2025; Press Information Bureau of India 2025).

I argue that Modi, who rose on a populist, anti-Muslim platform, faced a peace cost over a belligerence cost, incurring groupthink within the government and a perception of entrenchment. In other words, he believed there was no option but to escalate the exchange with Pakistan, and publicly disavowed strategic restraint (Destradi & Plagemann 2024).

How do groupthink and entrenchment operate? Deterrence works relationally: if you do this, then I won't do that. If you stop your attacks, I will not kill your people. Indian leadership could no longer credibly commit to stop escalation because groupthink inhibited critical assessment within state security organizations and entrenchment prevented leadership from domestic public attempts to stop the war.

In March of 2024, India completed necessary construction for a fast breeder reactor, gaining a nascent triad (Kristensen et al 2025). Alongside this, some senior Indian leaders have employed mixed rhetoric of abandoning NFU (Sultan 2018). These two actions indicate a move away from CMD and nuclear weapons moving beyond an object of prestige. These rhetorical and technical advances imply nuclear weapons as strategic, opening the door for more use-possibilities. This messaging created the condition of escalation, as it provided Pakistan with uncertainty of India's willingness or ability to de-escalate; "the resultant discord between its declaratory position and its ongoing developments may force Pakistan to take remedial measures that could lead to action-reaction syndrome, thus, causing instability in South Asia" (Sultan 2018, abs.). The "personality cult" of Modi allowed for this aggressive foreign policy (Khan & Khalid 2021) as those outside of sphere were marginalized, according to anonymized interviews (Destradi & Plagemann 2024). This personalization put increasing pressure on Modi to have a tough stance on Pakistan.

In tandem with Modi's rhetoric, the BJP was positioned to legitimize an attack on Pakistan through populism (Chacko 2018). Modi's hawkish rhetoric created the impression of less public constraint, real or perceived. Modi, an ultranationalist leader with an "authoritative and discriminatory style of politics" (Hafeez 2015), employs an anti-Muslim, anti-Pakistan agenda. The Modi government witnessed significant decline in Pakistan-India relations "because his

government has projected hawkish, discriminatory and aggressive policies toward Pakistan and particularly to Muslims within India and in Kashmir as compared to his predecessor” (Ijaz 2017, 83). Under Modi, restrictions to cross-cultural exchanges were implemented and Indians who sympathized with Pakistanis were targeted (Ijaz 2017, 89). In addition to restricting the rights of Muslims in India, Modi’s government normalized these abuses (Natesan 2014). Public antagonism towards Pakistan ratcheted up, those who would be against were increasingly silenced. Modi enjoyed high levels of support while India grew intolerant of its Muslim population (Clary et al 2022).

Escalation occurred because Modi believed he would face a higher cost to peace than belligerence, and he was right. A coalition has come to support Operation Sindoor from all sides of the political spectrum (Oneindia 2025). It also indicates that India no longer believes it can credibly deter Pakistan – it must use force (Tarapore 2025).

The deterrence failure of Pakistani attacks is abetted by entrenchment and groupthink.

Israel, 2018 to 2024

Israel as a Democracy

After World War II, the UK, through the UN, recommended its colony of Palestine be partitioned into Jewish and Arab states (Hammond 2010). Despite explicit denial of Palestinian independence in initial reporting and criticism from the Arab Higher Committee, the UN Special Committee on Palestine, backed by the United States, recommended the creation of the Jewish state of Israel, granting Jewish people over half the land despite being a third of the population at the time. This 1947 announcement and the ensuing British withdrawal from the region was immediately followed by a civil war, in which the Jewish people won and established the state of Israel (Golani 2001). Since then, Israel has fought several wars against its neighbor states as well as non-state actors, including Egypt, Lebanon, Hezbollah, and, most recently, Hamas. The Israeli state is internationally and domestically defined by its adherence to Western values in an illiberal (non-Western) neighborhood and its insecure relationship with Palestine and surrounding Arab nations (Mitzen 2006).

Since its inception, Israeli democracy has been primed for populism because of the inclusion/exclusion basis of its citizenry “namely, the specific nature of Jewish migration to Israel, the confrontation with the Palestinian indigenous population, and the ongoing colonial situation in the Occupied Territories.” (Filc 2009, 2) While Western liberal democracies emphasize the difference between the church and state as a way of marking the independence of federal government, “there are some states, however, that are manifestly ethnic” (Smootha 2002, 476). Israel was born to protect a certain church, and its democratic practices reflect such. Israeli citizens have Basic Laws that protect their rights, supported by a relatively independent judiciary, alongside regular, contested elections with a free press (Galnoor 2018). However, the state is propelled by ethnonationalism, which creates a “birthright” to the land and kinship to

fellow citizens. This creates an inherent inequality in the country – non-members of the ethnic nation “are not only regarded as less desirable but are also perceived as a serious threat to the survival and integrity of the ethnic nation” (Smootha 2002, 478). A religiously motivated population can threaten democracy because people may place the church above the law, may have less tolerance for others, or may have less respect for the constitution; Israel, to manage this, prioritized the Jewish “nature” of the state (Liebman 1995). The begrudging nature in which Israel has given rights to non-Jews has sowed the seeds for conflict. Thus, there have been claims that the Jewish population use the state as a tool for their interest and security, creating a strong ethnic bias within the population (Smootha 2002).

The nature, or existence, of Israeli democracy has long been questioned. From the lack of a formal constitution to minimal investment in liberal-democratic culture, Israel has increasingly failed to educate for democracy (Halperin & Bar-Tal 2006). In other words, it does not provide the breeding ground for values and practices of democracy. Alongside this bottom-up failure, the Israeli government has institutionalized discrimination and deliberately ignored legal protections for Arab citizens, particularly in its settlements (Eldar & Zertal 2004). Beyond that, its strict regulation of media channels limits freedom of press (Caspi 2005).

More recently, the rise and recapture of Israeli institutions by the current prime minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, has provoked accusations of democratic backsliding (Oren 2023; Oren & Waxman 2022).

Executive overreach in Israel is visible through the attacks on minority rights as well as undermining the courts and independent media. On minority rights, the Netanyahu government deterred immigration in acts like the 2014 Law for the Prevention of Infiltration and for Ensuring the Departure of Infiltrators from Israel, which targeted Palestinians as “infiltrators” and was later contested by the Israeli Supreme Court (Oren & Waxman 2022, 310). Additionally, the 2011 Nakba Law cut government funding for public institutions that mourned Palestine’s loss in 1947 (Shitrit 2016). In 2018, Netanyahu proposed a basic law that “explicitly affirms that only Jews have the right to self-determination in Israel, thereby effectively establishing two classes of citizens, Jews and non-Jews” and deliberately “omits any mention of democracy or the principle of equality” (Rabinovitch 2018). Together, these attempted to use executive power to put Jewish character over democratic status and prevent protection for other citizens’ rights. At the same time, Netanyahu changed the Israeli Supreme Court, proposing bills to restrict its power (Kremnitzer & Shany 2020). These included bills that wouldn’t let the Supreme Court rule on human rights or security issues or that would change the process of nominating judges. At the same time, Netanyahu attempted to bend the judiciary system by nominating loyalists in regulatory agencies. Finally, Netanyahu’s persistently attempted to control the media’s coverage of him, by interfering with licensing regulations (Berger 2019) or conspiring with media owners for favorable narratives (Oren & Waxman 2022, 313). At the same time, he used rhetorical attacks, calling the media “the enemy of the people” (Rogenhofer & Panievsky 2020, 1407).

Election manipulation was also present in Israel, as Netanyahu took incremental steps in changing who was allowed to participate in democracy. Like India, the right-wing nationalist movement's capacity can first be observed with its targeting of left-wing human rights non-governmental organizations (HRNGOs) through limiting funding, media framing as "foreign agents," and banning from engagement with public school students (Lamarche 2019). This set the stage for a 2016 law that made it easier for civil suits against HRNGOs and enabled public vilification of them as "traitorous" and "working against Israel" (Fleischmann 2019). These took the first step towards changing public perception. At the same time, Netanyahu changed electoral thresholds to prevent smaller, usually Arab/Arab-led, parties from taking seats in the Knesset, the Israeli parliamentary body (Navot et al 2017). Following, in 2019, two Arab parties were banned from participating in elections while far-right Jewish parties could run (Egash 2019). While this was overturned by the Supreme Court, it sent a clear signal that Israeli democracy was meant to serve its Jewish population. Additionally, the 2016 Dismissal Law meant a three-fourths majority of lawmakers can remove a member of the Knesset. This was passed in response to three Arab members consoling grieving Palestinian families who had been attacked by Israelis (Newman 2016). Finally, Netanyahu promoted intimidation tactics. On the day of voting, "Likud [a right-wing Jewish party] sent 1,200 party activists with hidden cameras exclusively to Palestinian polling stations to intimidate voters, based on fabricated claims of widespread voter fraud" (Reis 2019).

As was the case with India under Modi, Israeli under Netanyahu witnessed the consolidation of power into the executive branch which would continue perpetuate itself as the public and institutions lost control of democratic practices.

Israel, under Indecision and Disconnection

Israel, before the attacks by Hamas, suffered from a lack of red lines upheld by elites, which makes deterrence less credible as there's no wall to be backed against, and a perception of cost acceptance, because the public that holds leadership accountable cannot hold them responsible, which created the conditions for an adversarial move.

Since 1970, Israel has deployed a strategy of nuclear opacity -- "a situation in which a state's nuclear capability has not been acknowledged, but is recognized in a way that influences other nations' perceptions and actions" (Cohen 1998, 2). Israel navigated its nuclear weapon program delicately, as a series of reactions to both domestic and international pressures. Domestically, a *kdushat ha-bitachon* (sanctity of security) culture developed, so nuclear weapons were insulated from domestic politics. Internationally, its opacity balanced constant attack without inducing a preemptive strike by its neighbors, namely Egypt, and respect for the American nonproliferation policy. Thus, nuclear weapons in Israel served as a discreet mechanism for deterrence – under-the-radar and intended to ensure the survival of the state. While some call the actual role of nuclear weapons in deterrence marginal, this discretion enabled it to maintain its nuclear status and dictate its own nuclear strategy while avoiding all-out attacks from its adversaries and

maintaining positive relations with its Western allies (Maoz 2003; Karpin 2006). Israel is thought to have approximately 90 nuclear weapons (Kristensen et al 2025). Israeli nuclear opacity has persisted likely because “the lack of another nuclear state in the region, bipartisan support in the United States, and the lack of a well-established peace in the region” (BenLevi 2022, abs.) -- some of which are changing.

On October 7, 2023, the Palestinian terrorist organization Hamas attacked Israeli territory, kidnapping 239 and killing 1,144 citizens. It was the largest terror attack Israel had experienced (Codish et al 2024). In response, Israeli launched a war against the Palestinian people, with estimates of over 60,000 dead and over 150,000 injured at the time of this writing (UNOCHA 2025). The disproportional response has continued, despite international calls to stop and claims of genocide (Nijim 2023). Israeli government has long oppressed the Palestinian people, threatening their rights and property. Beyond that, Israel has always held the *Sampson Option* as part of its nuclear strategy: a willingness to use massive retaliation against an adversary even if destroy itself (Hersh 2013). Unlike typical MAD, the adversary does not need nuclear weapons. Rather, it just needs proximity to Israeli territory. This makes possible a nuclear option against the Palestinian people. Why, now, did a Palestinian organization attack Israel?

Israeli posturing made red lines less credible because they are less clear and less consistent. Schelling claims: “What we have to do is to get ourselves into a position where we cannot fail to react as we said we would—where we just cannot help it—or where we would be obliged by some overwhelming cost of not reacting in the manner we had declared” (1966, 43). If there is ambiguity in reaction, a deterrent threat evaporates. This, in the case of Israel, came from indecision and disconnection.

The secrecy of Israel’s nuclear program has long undermined its adherence to democratic forms of accountability: external experts are eschewed from oversight (Cohen 2010) and excludes checks and balances from non-executive branches (Israeli 2015). Any whistleblowers on Israeli nuclear operations face severe penalties (Kristensen & Korda 2022). At the same, time domestic political elites have little and lessening control over Israeli military actions writ large. Past responses to terrorist attacks indicates that Israeli responses are “made within a very small and intimate group headed by the leader and in most cases the Israeli decision-makers prefer to carry out a military operation on negotiations or any other course of action” (Sofrin 2021, abs.). Yet Netanyahu’s constant combat with heads of the Israeli security community indicated that he sat on thin ice, with some going as far to join demonstrations against him (Ziv 2024). It is no surprise, then, that Hamas perceived a moment of opportunity under his immediate return to office, as the shaky relationship between Netanyahu and the security community provided plausibility for indecision.

At the same time, disconnection ensued; Netanyahu no longer appeared constrained or attached to his constituency. The conservative elites heading his right-wing government fundamentally stood against the interests of their voter base (Gidron 2023). Beyond that, Netanyahu’s 2023

election provoked mass protests (Ziv 2024). Netanyahu was insulated from public backlash against his actions, allowing for disconnection. If adversarial states and organizations already believed Netanyahu was not beholden to public constraints, there was less credibility in his threats of retaliation.

The deterrence failure of an adversarial move was abetted by indecision and disconnection.

E. Conclusion

Trump, elected on a populist platform of a re-return to greatness and vendetta against his political opponents, is primed to face deterrence failures. Since reinhabiting the White House, Trump has worked to expand executive power, through mass-firing lifetime government bureaucrats, intimidating of the judiciary branch, and bullying members of Congress. At the same time, he pardoned January 6th rioters, implicitly and explicitly endorsing overturning elections and refusing peaceful transfer of power, while contemplating changes to voting eligibility. Yet inability to leverage American military strength into meaningful negotiations in Ukraine, despite campaign promises to end the war, is starting to signal that power may not come from tearing down democracy. If my theory holds, the nuclear-armed democracy that is the United States is headed towards an adversarial attack because of the indecision that has thus far plagued the Trump presidency, a prominent example being the constant reneging on tariffs, and the disconnection from public sentiment, from No Kings protests to citizens actively demonstrating against administration policies, a recent example of Alaskans supporting Ukraine during Putin's visit.

While giving major funding cuts to social services, Trump has reinvested in the American military and upheld expensive modernization programs for the nuclear arsenal. Deterrence isn't going to come from more money in nuclear weapons – it will come from reinvestment in democracy.

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